

DANGER AHEAD

Ergonomics, the applied science of equipment design, is working hard to take the stress off our working lifestyles

A diti stretched back in her chair and shut her eyes. She put down her specs and massaged the bunched up muscles in her neck; that nagging pain in the neck had spread to the middle of her back. She cracked her knuckles and flexed her fingers. Her eyes were burning. "Ah well! A good night's rest and cold pad for the eyes will take care of that." Thinking this, she shut down her PC and picked up her bag to go home.

Sounds familiar? This probably describes how most of us who spend long hours sitting in front of the computer feel at the end of the day. We are slowly waking up to the fact that our stressful work habits may be the cause of the constant discomfort we feel but can't put our fin-

ger on. Statistics show a rise in health hazards related to a sedentary life spent at the desk, usually in front of the computer—of all occupational illnesses, musculoskeletal disorders rose from 18 per cent in 1985 to 52 per cent in 1989 and 56 per cent in 1991. Other studies show that 31 per cent of medical claims made by employees pertaining to a computer environment involved back strain. The medical compensation caused by these and other work-related health hazards exceed \$100 billion annually in the US alone.

This awareness has given rise to the study of ergonomics: the bio-technology working towards reducing the stress caused by our daily tools of work to maximise productivity and reduce operator

fatigue and discomfort. Ergonomic disorders such as Carpel Tunnel Syndrome (CTS), various tendon disorders and lower back injuries are among the most-rapidly growing recordable injuries and illnesses. Thus, increasingly more number of organisations and users are opting for their equipment to be designed and arranged to facilitate a healthy and efficient working environment.

In an environment where computers are used, ergonomics is applied to the physical design of the peripherals that we come in direct contact with, such as the keyboard, screens and the mouse. And this wave of change in work environments has come around the right time. The hazards of constant computing and addiction show

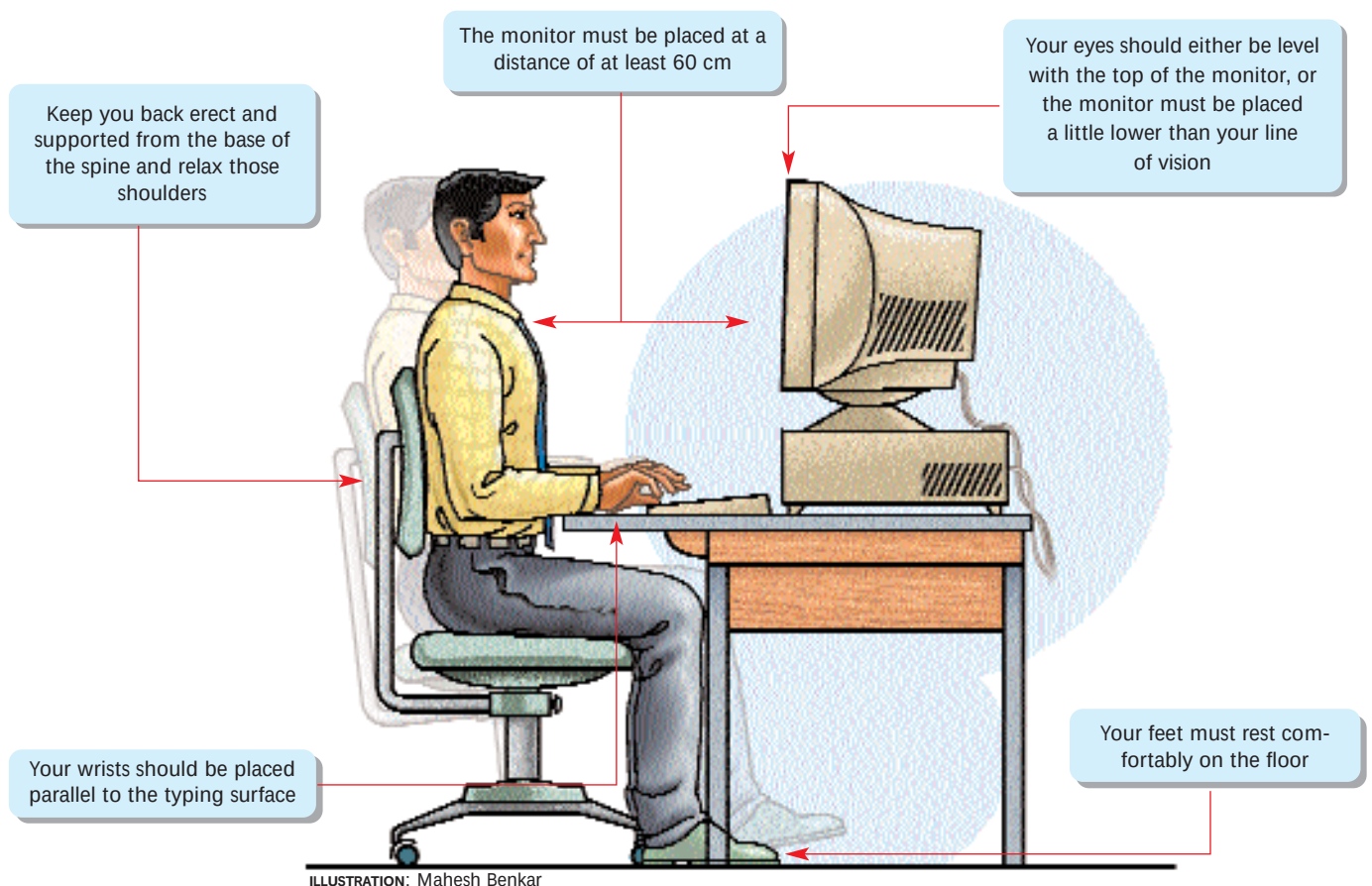


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